

Gadget Of Our Dreams?

Gadgets, gizmos and all things tech that we love... What can we expect to see in the near future, and more importantly, what do we want?



Imaging Shrikishna Patkar

Robert Sovereign-Smith

Of all the technology subjects we talk about, this one sets our senses tingling the most—our Sixth Sense, that is. Personal Technology is also the hardest area to play soothsayer for, because if the past is any indication of the future, it will change consistently, radically, and at a very brisk pace. In under a decade, we, the end-users, have gone from hunting for Public Call Offices (PCOs) to making and receiving calls while roaming the globe. A large percentage of you have only started using cameras in the last five years, and already most of you have digital cameras. Net access is also not confined to PCs anymore: today, it's accessible via your phone, laptop, or PDA. Call rates have fallen from as much as Rs 16 per minute to a pittance.

We Indians bear witness to the way personal devices have infiltrated the common man's life. But what's the future got in store for us?

Convergence

Convergence, which was quite the buzzword two years ago—our June 2005 anniversary issue talked about it—is something we take for granted today. Almost every mobile phone has a camera, can play music (FM/digital audio), does basic Personal Information Management (PIM), and a host of other functions. The big addition in recent times has been Net access. Gaming is another popular use for Indian mobiles. We're not playing *Half-Life 2* on our phones (yet), but *Snake*, *Bejeweled*... you get the idea. Faster hardware and better mobile soft-

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ware platforms have added the ability to run applications from simple Java games to complex software such as Documents To Go (PDFs, Word, Excel, and more). Touch-screens and PDA-like functionality are now becoming the norm in mobile devices of note, with prices starting from as little as 14K.

As we've discussed elsewhere, India is all set to bypass 3G altogether, and jump onto the 4G bandwagon. This means blazing fast Net access for mobile devices (compared to today, at any rate), which will mean we can expect to see more online services for mobile devices. Streaming video and audio to your mobile devices will be the norm, and content providers will start cropping up. This is only a natural progression; the only thing limiting this is network bandwidth (or the lack of it). A shift to 4G, whenever that is, will end all our bandwidth woes—whether it brings all-new ones along with it remains to be seen!

As mobile phones go, the market buzz is all about Apple's iPhone. Apart from a 480 x 320 multi-touch screen, it runs OS X, has a 2MP camera, Wi-Fi, EDGE, Bluetooth 2.0, and 4 / 8 GB Flash memory. It should be out in the US by the time you read this, and will hopefully be available in India soon.

What's important about the iPhone is that it's running a lite-OS, which makes much more possible on mobile devices than making calls and basic Internet connectivity.

Nokia's latest mobile, the N95, has a 5MP camera, and can record video at 30 fps 640 x 480 (VGA). Quite some time ago, we mentioned Samsung's SCH-V770, a prototype 7MP camera with phone functionality, which was Samsung's way of telling everyone, "We did it just because we could." Expect 5MP cameras to be the norm in a few years, if not less.

Almost every phone today doubles up as an MP3 player, with maximum capacities ranging from as little as 256 MB to as much as 4 GB. And not just the MP3 format, but AAC, WAV, WMV, and more, just like any standalone MP3 player. With screens getting bigger and better on mobile devices, video playback is the order of the day. Mostly in the 3GPP/3GPP2 format, but support for .AVI, .MOV, .WMV, etc., is improving. You can get a DivX player for your Palm / Symbian / UIQ / Smartphone / PocketPC device from <http://mobile.divx.com/>.

As you can see, portable entertainment is no longer only a laptop or media device function, it's now coming to your mobiles. With 4G bandwidth, you can theoretically stream HD content to your devices; mobile audio / video looks promising.

The biggest road block for every convergent device, however, is storage. Hard drives are slow